

QUESTION 26

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: In 2019 a school in Helsinki replaced its fixed classroom desks with movable stools and rolling tables. Administrators had expected the change to register in attendance figures, which had been drifting downward for three years; attendance did not move at all. What teachers did record, in logs kept across two terms, was that students shifted seats an average of four times per lesson, and that the pairings formed at those moments were rarely the pairings students had chosen at the start of class. Education researcher Liisa Ranta, who analyzed the logs, argues that the school's experience points to something the seating literature has largely missed: flexible arrangements matter less for how comfortable or autonomous students report feeling, measures on which the Helsinki students barely moved, than for how often a student ends up working beside someone they would never have selected. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A: To use one school's experience as the basis for a claim about what flexible seating primarily affects
- B: To report the attendance and self-report measures a Finnish school recorded after changing its seating
- C: To describe how frequently students in flexible classrooms change seats over the course of a lesson
- D: To recommend that schools adopt movable seating in order to broaden students' working partnerships

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: TECHNIQUE - LAST VOICE RULE. On a long research passage, do not start summarizing from the top. Find the last named person who makes a claim and read their sentence first. Everything before it is almost always the setup that earns them the right to say it. Here that person is Ranta, and her sentence carries the word 'matter less... than,' which is a ranking. A ranking sentence is a purpose sentence. Map the passage as three blocks: what was expected (attendance), what was found (seat shifts), what it means (Ranta). Only block three is the point. Why A: it captures the move from one school to a general claim. Why not B and C: both live inside block two, and data that exists to support a claim is never the purpose. C is tempting because 'four times per lesson' is the most concrete fact on the page, and concrete facts feel important. Train yourself to distrust that feeling. Why not D: Ranta describes what seating does, not what schools should do. No 'should' appears anywhere.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 27

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Ask most people what a camel keeps in its hump and the answer comes quickly: water. The hump in fact holds fat, a store the animal metabolizes for energy across the long intervals when forage is scarce, and a camel whose hump has slumped after a hard season is short of calories rather than of water. The animal's real defenses against dehydration lie elsewhere in its body. Oval red blood cells keep circulating as the blood thickens; the kidneys concentrate urine to a degree few mammals tolerate; and a camel can shed a quarter of its body weight in water, then rehydrate in minutes without the cell damage such a swing would inflict on other species. The hump belief endures partly because it offers one tidy answer where the true one is distributed across half a dozen organs. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A: To survey the range of physiological adaptations that allow camels to endure arid environments
- B: To correct a common misunderstanding about camel humps and locate the animal's actual water defenses
- C: To explain how a camel's blood and kidneys permit it to tolerate rapid losses of body water
- D: To account for why an inaccurate belief about camels has proved so difficult to dislodge

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: TECHNIQUE - BOOKEND CHECK. When a passage opens by naming a belief, read the final sentence immediately before doing anything else. If the ending returns to that belief, the passage is a correction and the middle is just evidence. Here sentence one gives the myth (water) and the last sentence returns to why the myth survives. Everything between is the corrective payload. Why B: it names both halves the correction needs, the false function and the true one. Why not A: this is the trap that catches strong readers. Four adaptations really are listed, and by word ninety a student has forgotten the passage began with a myth. That is exactly what the length is doing to you. The list exists to answer 'if not the hump, then what,' so it is subordinate. Why not C: one item from that list. Why not D: takes the closing clause alone. A final sentence explains a leftover puzzle; it rarely carries the purpose.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 28

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: For most of the nineteenth century, ships carried ice cut from New England ponds to ports as distant as Havana, Rio de Janeiro, and Calcutta. The blocks were sawed in winter, stacked in insulated icehouses, and packed in sawdust for voyages that could run four months; a cargo arriving at two-thirds of its loaded weight counted as a success, and at its height the trade employed thousands of cutters, teamsters, and shipping agents in Boston alone. Frederic Tudor, who spent two decades and several fortunes proving the business viable, died wealthy in 1864. Within two decades of the 1870s the industry had all but vanished. Mechanical refrigeration, refined in Germany and France and taken up first by breweries and packing houses, made it possible to manufacture ice locally at any latitude, and a Calcutta merchant had no further reason to wait four months for a New England pond. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

A: To describe the techniques that allowed harvested ice to survive months at sea

B: To trace the rise of the New England ice trade and the career of the merchant who established it

C: To explain how a technological development brought a long-established trade to an end

D: To argue that mechanical refrigeration was the most consequential innovation of the late nineteenth century

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: TECHNIQUE - PIVOT HUNT. Long history passages are usually built as LONG SETUP then SHORT REVERSAL. Skim for the sentence where the situation flips, and mark it. Here it is eight words: 'Within two decades of the 1870s the industry had all but vanished.' Everything before is scale-building so the collapse registers; everything after is the cause. Why C: it names the reversal and its cause together. Why not B: this covers roughly seventy percent of the words, which is precisely why it tempts. Word count is not purpose. A passage can spend a hundred words building something in order to knock it down. Why not A: sawdust and icehouses are texture. Why not D: 'most consequential innovation of the late nineteenth century' is a superlative, and the text never compares refrigeration to anything else. Superlatives in options are usually invented.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 29

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Ecologists use the term 'shifting baseline syndrome' for a tendency in which each generation of researchers treats the conditions they first encountered as the natural state of a system. The consequences show most clearly in fisheries. A cod population reduced to a tenth of its eighteenth-century abundance may be described as healthy by scientists who began work in the 1980s, since it matches what they measured at the start of their own careers, and a further decline of thirty percent, judged against that lowered mark, registers as a modest fluctuation rather than as the last stage of a collapse. The pattern is not a failure of individual competence. It follows from the fact that both memory and monitoring records are short, and that the earlier state of most ecosystems survives only in ships' logs, market receipts, and other sources ecologists are not trained to read. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A: To describe the long-term decline of North Atlantic cod populations
- B: To argue that ecologists should be trained to work with historical documentary sources
- C: To criticize a generation of researchers for misjudging the health of the systems they studied
- D: To introduce a concept and explain how the pattern it names distorts environmental assessments

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: TECHNIQUE - TERM FIRST RULE. If a passage names and defines a term in its opening sentence, the term is the subject and every later sentence is illustration, no matter how vivid. Circle the term, then label the rest: cod = example, 'not a failure of competence' = guard, ships' logs = cause. Why D: names the concept and what it does to assessments. Why not A: cod are the worked example. A long example can occupy half the passage and still be an example. Why not C: this one is dead on arrival, and the passage kills it for you in a single sentence: 'not a failure of individual competence.' Whenever a text explicitly disowns blame, delete every option that assigns blame before reading further. Why not B: the closing clause about untrained ecologists is a cause of the pattern, not a recommendation. Watch for options that turn a described cause into a proposed fix.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 30

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Materials scientist Yusuf Demir began with a question about beetles. The shells of several desert species stay nearly free of dust in conditions where a smooth surface of any material fouls within hours, and electron microscopy showed why: the shell carries bumps roughly a hundred nanometers across, which cut the area a particle can touch to a small fraction of what a flat surface offers. Demir's group reproduced that geometry in a transparent silica film and applied it to photovoltaic panels at three test sites in Anatolia. Across eighteen months the coated panels needed cleaning roughly half as often as untreated ones, and the coating cost less than the water it saved. Demir notes that the advantage narrowed almost to nothing in the two wettest months of the trial, when rain cleaned both surfaces about equally. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A: To describe how a structure observed in nature was adapted into a working technology
- B: To explain why the shells of certain desert beetles resist the accumulation of dust
- C: To report the maintenance and cost results of an eighteen-month trial of coated solar panels
- D: To identify the conditions under which a bio-inspired panel coating fails to deliver an advantage

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: TECHNIQUE - BRIDGE TEST. Some passages cross from one domain to another, here from insect biology to solar engineering. When you spot a crossing, the purpose must span both banks. Any option that sits entirely on one side is automatically wrong, however accurate it is. Why A: 'observed in nature... adapted into a working technology' is the bridge itself. Why not B: the beetle bank. Why not C: the panel bank. Both are true statements about the passage, and both are half a passage. This is the most common way long science texts punish students, because at 140 words each half is substantial enough to feel like the whole. Why not D: the wet-months caveat is the final sentence. A closing qualification tells you the writer is being careful; it does not tell you why the piece was written. Get in the habit of asking whether a sentence would survive if the rest were deleted.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 31

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: The following text is from Adaye Nwosu's 2021 novel *The Long Verandah*. Every surface in Mr. Obi's front room had been set at right angles. The newspapers lay squared to the table's edge and were removed each Sunday whether or not they had been read; the shoes stood paired beneath the bench in descending order of age; the clock was wound every morning before the kettle went on, and had not in eleven years been permitted to run down. His daughter, visiting from Enugu, once moved a chair eighteen inches to catch the light while she read, and found it restored to its position the next morning without comment or reproach, as though the chair had walked back on its own. Visitors said the room felt less like a home than like a ledger, and Mr. Obi, who overheard this once, appeared to take it as a compliment. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A: To describe the domestic routines that structured Mr. Obi's daily life
- B: To convey a character's disposition through the arrangement of his surroundings
- C: To depict an unspoken conflict between Mr. Obi and his visiting daughter
- D: To suggest that Mr. Obi is unaware of how others perceive his household

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: TECHNIQUE - ABSENT SUBJECT RULE. In fiction, ask who the passage claims to be about and who it actually describes. Here the answer is a man, but not one sentence describes Mr. Obi directly. It describes newspapers, shoes, a clock, a chair. When objects get all the sentences and the person gets none, the objects are doing the characterizing, and that transfer is the purpose. Why B: 'disposition through the arrangement of his surroundings' names the transfer. Why not A: routines are the raw material. Saying the passage is about his routines is like saying a portrait is about paint. Why not C: the chair moment is four lines out of fourteen and contains no conflict; nobody argues, and the text says 'without comment or reproach.' Long passages give you sub-scenes, and sub-scenes attract wrong answers. Why not D: directly contradicted. He overhears the ledger remark and is pleased.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 32

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: The Colorado River delta, which once supported nearly two million acres of wetland and cottonwood forest, has received almost no freshwater since the 1960s, and the stands that remain survive on groundwater rather than on surface flow. Hydrologist Marisol Vega has modeled what follows if the current allocation agreements are renewed on their existing terms. Under that scenario the water table beneath the delta keeps falling at the rate measured since 2004, drops below the root depth of the surviving cottonwoods within roughly fifteen years, and ends the last natural regeneration of the forest; the mature trees would persist a further decade or two, but no seedling germinating after that point would reach water. Vega's model assumes no change in regional precipitation, an assumption she describes as the most favorable of the several available to her. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

A: To describe the losses the Colorado River delta has already sustained since freshwater deliveries ceased

B: To argue that existing water allocation agreements should be revised rather than renewed

C: To present a projection of what will happen to a forest if current water allocations continue

D: To identify the assumptions that limit the reliability of a hydrological model

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: TECHNIQUE - TENSE SCAN. Before choosing, sweep the passage for its dominant tense. Past tense means reporting; conditional plus future ('if... would') means projecting. Mixing them is how this question traps people: sentence one is genuinely historical, and a student who anchors on the opening never notices the passage turns into a model at sentence two. Why C: the body of the text is Vega's scenario, expressed in 'would.' Why not A: the strongest trap on the page. It describes sentence one accurately. Ask yourself how many words sit under each tense, and the answer becomes obvious. Why not B: 'should be revised' never appears. A projection of harm is not a call to act, even when the harm sounds urgent. Test writers rely on you supplying the recommendation yourself. Why not D: the precipitation assumption is one closing sentence of self-audit.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 33

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: The following text is from Iona Fairbairn's 2020 poetry collection *Second Weather*. All winter I called the field empty / and walked its edge the way one walks past a locked house, / counting the fence posts, not looking in. / I had my reasons. Nothing moved there. / The snow lay flat as a closed account / and the crows that crossed it did not stop. / Then in March the ice drew back / in one long afternoon, the way a sleeve is pushed up an arm, / and the whole ground was seed, had been seed, / had been counting the days I was not looking, / had been doing the slow arithmetic of roots / beneath the exact square yard I crossed each morning / and named for what I could not see in it. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

A: To celebrate the arrival of spring following a long and severe winter

B: To convey the speaker's shame at having misjudged a place she passed every day

C: To describe the physical process by which a frozen field thaws and begins to grow

D: To trace the speaker's shift from seeing a place as empty to recognizing activity present all along

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: TECHNIQUE - TENSE SHIFT IN VERSE. Poetry rarely announces its purpose, so track the verbs. Here the poem moves from simple past ('I called,' 'walked') to past perfect ('had been seed, had been counting'). Past perfect reaches back and rewrites what was already narrated. When a poem revises its own earlier account, the subject is the speaker's seeing, not the thing seen. Why D: names the shift from 'empty' to 'active all along.' Why not C: the field never changes in the poem. Only the speaker's knowledge does. This is the single most useful distinction in DSAT poetry questions. Why not B: 'I had my reasons' and 'named for what I could not see' carry self-reproach, so B is not false, merely small. The poem uses regret to power a realization; it does not stop at regret. Why not A: no celebration appears, and spring is the occasion rather than the topic.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 34

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: The following text is from Bela Kovacs's 2019 novel *The Inventory*. I have never been sentimental about objects, which is why I keep so few. The desk was my father's, but I kept it for the drawers, which are deep and well made and would cost a great deal to replace. The watch I kept because a watch is useful, and because the strap was new. The photograph in the second drawer I have not looked at in years. I could not tell you today which summer it was taken, or who else was standing outside the frame, though I could tell you the weather, and that the light on the water behind us was the flat white it goes at four in the afternoon in August, and that my mother had said something just before, which is why my father is turning. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A: To open a distance between what a narrator claims about himself and what his account reveals
- B: To present the practical grounds on which the narrator has retained a few inherited possessions
- C: To convey the narrator's unresolved grief over the loss of his parents
- D: To illustrate how vividly sensory detail can survive after other memories have faded

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: TECHNIQUE - CONTRADICTION SWEEP. With a first-person narrator, read the opening self-description as a claim under test, not as information. Then hunt for evidence that fails it. Here the claim is 'never sentimental about objects.' By the close he has recalled the exact quality of August light and the reason his father is turning, about a photograph he says he never looks at. The gap is the point. Why A: names the distance between his claim and his evidence. Why not B: this accepts his stated reasons, which is exactly the reading the passage is engineered to defeat. Why not D: the sharpest trap here. The sensory detail is genuine and vivid, so an option praising vivid sensory memory sounds like a fair summary. But the detail is not there to teach you about memory; it is there to catch him out. Ask what a detail does in the passage, not what it is. Why not C: no death, no parents' loss, nothing confirmed. Do not import a story.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 35

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Psychologist Ilse Brandt set out to reproduce a finding that has circulated widely in the popular press: that brief exposure to natural settings improves short-term memory. Across four experiments involving 1,200 participants, those who walked ten minutes in a wooded park before testing recalled no more digits, words, or spatial positions than those who walked ten minutes along a commercial street, and the confidence intervals were narrow enough to rule out even a small effect. Brandt is careful about what this does and does not show. The studies that first reported a benefit used walks of an hour or more, several of them with participants already fatigued by testing, and it remains possible that duration, recovery from fatigue, or both are doing the work. What her data exclude is the ten-minute version of the claim, which is the version most often repeated. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A: To argue that time spent in natural settings has no measurable effect on cognitive performance
- B: To describe the experimental design by which Brandt tested a widely circulated claim
- C: To identify the version of a popular claim that is most frequently misreported
- D: To report that a study failed to find an expected effect and to identify a possible reason for the discrepancy

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: TECHNIQUE - NULL PLUS HEDGE. When a study finds nothing, check immediately whether the researcher hedges. A bare null result and a hedged null result have different purposes. Brandt hedges twice: earlier studies used longer walks, and duration or fatigue may be doing the work. That hedge must appear in your answer. Why D: 'failed to find an expected effect' plus 'a possible reason for the discrepancy' matches both moves. Why not A: this is the answer a student picks when they stop reading at the results sentence, which on a 140-word passage is around the halfway mark. Brandt explicitly declines to say nature has no effect; she says the ten-minute version fails. Why not C: the final clause about the most-repeated version is a closing flourish. Why not B: design is method. Method answers are almost never correct on purpose questions unless the method itself is the innovation, as in Q37.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 36

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: It has long been assumed that people who sleep badly become more anxious as a consequence, and clinical guidance in several countries reflects that order. Sleep researcher Nadia Oyelaran tracked 900 adults over two years, collecting weekly anxiety scores alongside actigraphy readings rather than self-reported sleep duration. In roughly seventy percent of participants who experienced both, the rise in anxiety scores preceded the decline in sleep quality by between two and nine weeks; in the remainder the order was reversed or the two moved together. Oyelaran does not claim that poor sleep leaves anxiety untouched, and notes that once both are established each appears to worsen the other. Her argument is narrower: that in most of the cases she followed, a treatment directed at sleep alone would have been addressing the later of two linked problems rather than the earlier one. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A: To demonstrate that anxiety and poor sleep are more strongly correlated than earlier work suggested
- B: To present evidence reversing an assumed causal order and to note what it implies for treatment
- C: To argue that poor sleep plays no role in worsening anxiety once both conditions are established
- D: To recommend that clinical guidance on the treatment of insomnia be revised in several countries

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: TECHNIQUE - ORDER VERSUS STRENGTH. Causal passages come in two flavors: how strongly two things are linked, and in what order they occur. Read for the verb that signals sequence. Here it is 'preceded, rather than followed,' with a specific lag of two to nine weeks. That is order, not strength. Why B: reverses the assumed order and carries the treatment implication Oyelaran draws. Why not A: swaps order for correlation. Two variables can be strongly correlated with the arrow pointing either way, so an option about correlation cannot capture a finding about sequence. Why not C: contradicted by the sentence granting that each worsens the other once both exist. On long passages, researchers routinely insert a concession like this specifically so a distractor can overstate their position. Why not D: 'recommend that guidance be revised' goes one step past what she says.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 37

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Analyzing ancient seabed sediment ordinarily requires lifting a core to the surface, an operation that consumes weeks of ship time, costs upward of forty thousand dollars a day, and disturbs the fine layering that makes the core worth reading in the first place. Geochemist Tobias Lindgren has built a probe that measures oxygen and carbon isotope ratios in place, lowering a spectrometer housing to the seafloor and returning results within hours. Deployed at a site off the Chilean coast that had been cored in 2011, the probe reproduced the earlier expedition's isotope values to within the margin of the original laboratory analysis, across a depth range that expedition had needed two months to sample. Lindgren notes that the probe cannot yet resolve layers thinner than four centimeters, which rules out the annual-resolution work some paleoclimate questions require. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A: To report new findings about the isotope composition of sediments off the Chilean coast
- B: To explain why conventional seabed coring is costly and destructive of the material it recovers
- C: To introduce an instrument that shortens a costly process and to establish that its results are reliable
- D: To identify the resolution limits that currently restrict a new sediment-measuring instrument

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: TECHNIQUE - NEW VERSUS KNOWN. When a passage reports measurements, ask whether the numbers are new. Here the probe 'reproduced the earlier expedition's isotope values,' meaning the numbers were already known since 2011. Nothing was discovered. That single observation eliminates the discovery option instantly and tells you the instrument is the news. Why C: introduces the tool and establishes reliability, which is exactly the two-part job the passage performs. Why not A: the trap for anyone reading quickly, since the passage is full of isotopes and a Chilean site and therefore looks like a findings report. Why not B: the opening cost-and-damage sentence establishes why a new tool matters. Openings on long passages are background more often than not. Why not D: the four-centimeter limit is a closing caveat, and a caveat on a tool presupposes the tool has already been introduced as the subject.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 38

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: The stone tools recovered from Kanjera South in Kenya were catalogued in the early 1990s and interpreted, on the basis of edge damage and their association with butchered bone, as hunting and butchery implements. Archaeologist Wren Delacroix returned to the same museum drawers thirty years later with high-resolution microscopy and a reference library of plant residues that did not exist when the collection was first described. On fourteen of the sixty tools she examined she identified starch granules and polish patterns consistent with the processing of underground tubers, a food source that leaves almost nothing in the archaeological record. Delacroix excavated nothing and collected no new material; her claim rests entirely on objects the original team had already brought to the surface, and she is explicit that the butchery interpretation of the remaining tools still stands. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A: To report the discovery of new evidence that early humans processed plant foods
- B: To argue that microscopic residue analysis is more reliable than the methods available in the 1990s
- C: To describe the excavation that first recovered the stone tool assemblage at Kanjera South
- D: To describe how a fresh analysis of previously collected material produced a different interpretation

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: TECHNIQUE - NEGATION SENTENCE. Long passages often contain one sentence whose only job is to block a wrong answer. Learn to spot it. Here it is 'Delacroix excavated nothing and collected no new material.' A sentence that denies something you were never told is a signpost: the writer is protecting you from a specific misreading. Why D: 'fresh analysis of previously collected material' matches the denial exactly. Why not A: the misreading the negation sentence was built to stop. Starch granules and tubers sound like a discovery, and at 136 words the denial sits far from the exciting part. Why not B: one reanalysis does not establish that microscopy beats older methods generally, and the passage keeps the earlier butchery reading for the other forty-six tools. Why not C: the 1990s cataloguing is background. Whenever an option describes the earlier work rather than the new work, check whether the new work is what the passage is announcing.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 39

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Cities that replace sodium streetlights with bright white LEDs report electricity savings of forty to sixty percent and measurable gains in drivers' ability to distinguish objects at the roadside. The same fixtures emit substantially more short-wavelength light, which scatters further in the atmosphere, disrupts the navigation of moths and other nocturnal insects, and has been linked in three European studies to reduced nocturnal pollination in gardens within a hundred meters of a converted street. Lighting engineer Sofia Marchetti observes that the two bodies of evidence usually reach councils separately, from different departments, and argues that neither figure on its own should decide a conversion program. Warmer-toned LEDs recover most of the energy saving at a fraction of the ecological cost, but they are rarely specified, because the procurement documents most councils use ask only about lumens per watt. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A: To present the advantages and the ecological costs of a technology and to caution against weighing either alone
- B: To argue that councils should specify warmer-toned LEDs in their street lighting procurement
- C: To explain how short-wavelength light interferes with the navigation of nocturnal insects
- D: To report the electricity savings that cities have achieved by converting to LED streetlights

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: TECHNIQUE - SCALE STRUCTURE. Some passages build a balance: pan one, pan two, then a refusal to tip. Sketch it as you read. Pan one is savings and visibility; pan two is insect navigation and pollination; the refusal is 'neither figure on its own should decide.' When a refusal sentence exists, it is the purpose, and every single-pan option dies. Why A: carries both pans plus the refusal. Why not B: the hardest trap in the easy-to-medium band. The last sentence really does point toward warmer LEDs, and students reason that a writer who mentions a solution must be advocating it. But it appears as an illustration of how procurement keeps the two pans apart. Why not C and D: one pan each. Note how a 138-word passage gives each pan enough material to feel complete on its own. That is the whole trick of the long form.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 40

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: A trial reported in 2023 found that productivity held steady at 61 companies that moved to a four-day week, and the result was widely summarized as evidence that the shorter week works. Economist Rahel Bekele has examined the sample. Every participating firm volunteered, which selects for managers who already expected the change to succeed; most employed fewer than 200 people, so the coordination costs that grow with headcount were largely absent; and nearly all operated in professional services, where output is counted in completed projects rather than in machine hours. Bekele does not dispute the trial's internal findings and calls the design careful within its scope. Her argument is that the sample cannot support the sentence the coverage attached to it, and that the manufacturing and large-employer cases the debate actually turns on remain untested. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

A: To argue that a widely publicized workweek trial was poorly designed and its results unreliable

B: To identify limits on the range of workplaces to which a trial's findings can be extended

C: To criticize press coverage for overstating the conclusions of a research trial

D: To describe the characteristics of the companies that took part in a four-day-week trial

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: TECHNIQUE - CONCESSION LINE. When one researcher critiques another's work, find the sentence where they concede something. It fixes the scope of the attack. Bekele's concession is unusually strong: she 'does not dispute the trial's internal findings' and calls the design 'careful within its scope.' So the critique cannot be about quality. That leaves reach. Why B: limits on which workplaces the findings extend to. Why not A: killed by the concession. Students pick it because three sentences of sample criticism read like an attack on the study; the concession arrives afterward and gets overwritten in memory. On long passages, always check whether a later sentence redefines what came before. Why not C: the closest miss. Coverage is mentioned, but her target is what the sample can support, not who reported it badly. Why not D: the three sample features are her evidence, not her conclusion.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 41

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: The following text is from Hugo Almeida's 2018 novel *Blue Hour*. 'You could have called,' his mother said. Daniel set out the sequence for her: the connecting flight cancelled at Lisbon, the ninety minutes at the rebooking desk, the train that left from a different station than the one printed on the voucher, the two hours in Porto with a phone at four percent and no adapter that fit the outlets there. He was thorough. He gave her the times, and where he was not certain of a time he said so. She listened to all of it. She nodded once, at the part about the adapter, and when he had finished she said, in the same voice but more quietly, 'You could have called.' He heard this as a failure to follow the sequence, and began again from the airport, slower this time, because Lisbon was where people usually lost the thread. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

A: To describe the series of travel disruptions that delayed Daniel's arrival home

B: To convey a mother's disappointment at not having heard from her son

C: To depict an exchange in which two people address different concerns without either recognizing it

D: To illustrate Daniel's inability to recognize when an account has already been received

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: TECHNIQUE - REPEATED LINE. In dialogue, an exactly repeated sentence is never accidental. Ask what changed between the two utterances. Here nothing changed except volume, which means the first utterance was never answered. He supplied a timeline; she asked about care. The repetition marks the miss, and his restarting from the airport proves he has not registered it. Why C: two people addressing different concerns, neither noticing. Why not D: the sharpest trap, because it is half correct. Daniel genuinely does not grasp what she wants. But the scene is built on a two-sided failure, and D charges only him. When a passage stages a gap between two people, prefer the option that holds both. Why not A: takes his account at face value, treating the passage as a travel report. The flight details fill half the word count precisely to bait this. Why not B: takes her side alone and names an emotion the text leaves implicit.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 42

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: The following text is from Rania Kabbani's 2022 essay collection *The Second Language*. Learning a language after thirty is less like filling a vessel than like moving into a house where someone still lives. The furniture is not yours and cannot be moved far. You learn which stairs complain and which window will not shut in November, and you acquire the small courtesies of a tenant: you do not rearrange, you do not ask why the kitchen was built facing north. For the first year you apologize to the previous occupant every time you take a wrong turn in the hallway. Later you stop apologizing, and later still you stop noticing that you have stopped, though you never quite stop hearing her on the floor above, moving something heavy from one room into another, in the grammar you were born into. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A: To argue that adults acquire a second language less readily than children do
- B: To describe the particular difficulties the writer encountered while learning a second language
- C: To explain why traces of a first language persist in the speech of adult learners
- D: To develop a sustained comparison that conveys what learning a language later in life feels like

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: TECHNIQUE - ONE IMAGE TEST. Count how many distinct images a passage uses. If a single comparison runs through every sentence, developing that comparison is the purpose, and options that translate the image into plain claims are wrong by construction. Here the house appears in furniture, stairs, a window, a tenant's courtesies, apologies in a hallway, and footsteps overhead. Nothing escapes it. Why D: a sustained comparison conveying how the experience feels. Why not C: the trap for careful readers, since the closing phrase 'in the grammar you were born into' does gesture at first-language interference. But the essay renders a feeling; it never explains a mechanism, gives a cause, or cites evidence. Why not B: reads the house literally as a list of difficulties, which mistakes the vehicle for the tenor. Why not A: children are never mentioned. An option comparing two groups needs both groups on the page.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 43

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Surveys of North Atlantic seabird colonies have reported declines of up to forty percent since 2005, while at-sea counts of the same species across the same period show populations essentially stable. Marine ecologist Petra Halvorsen argues that both records are probably accurate and that the contradiction is an artifact of where each one looks. Warming water has pushed sandeel and capelin stocks north and offshore. Birds that once bred on the monitored island colonies, most of which were chosen for monitoring in the 1970s because they were reachable by boat, have shifted to mainland cliffs nearer the new foraging grounds, and almost none of those cliffs appear in any long-running survey. Halvorsen adds that a redistribution this rapid carries risks of its own, and that stability in the at-sea counts should not be read as evidence that the populations are secure. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A: To argue that at-sea counts measure seabird abundance more accurately than colony surveys do
- B: To warn that current monitoring programs are understating the severity of seabird decline
- C: To describe how warming water has redistributed the prey species on which North Atlantic seabirds depend
- D: To offer an account under which two apparently contradictory sets of data can both be correct

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: TECHNIQUE - BOTH TRUE THESIS. When a passage opens with two findings that appear to clash, read on for one sentence: does the writer choose, or reconcile? Halvorsen's sentence is 'both records are probably accurate,' which is a reconciliation. Once you see it, every option that crowns a winner is eliminated without further thought. Why D: an account under which both datasets can be correct. Why not A: picks the at-sea counts. Why not B: the most dangerous option on this page, because it feels like the responsible environmental answer and rewards a student who is skimming for tone. It also inverts the logic. The colony surveys overstate decline, since the birds moved rather than died. Read the direction of an error, not just the fact of one. Why not C: prey redistribution is the mechanism that makes reconciliation possible, a supporting part.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 44

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Students who play in school orchestras score, on average, half a standard deviation higher on standardized mathematics tests than students who do not, a gap cited in support of arts funding for two decades. Education researcher Malik Osei sets out what a family must supply before a child can join one: an instrument, which most programs require families to rent; private lessons, since ensemble rehearsal assumes a baseline of technique the school day does not provide; and transportation to evening practices. Families able to furnish all three differ from other families in household income, parental education, and residential stability, each of which independently predicts test performance. Osei's position is not that musical training does nothing. It is that a comparison between orchestra members and non-members cannot separate the effect of the training from the effect of everything that had to be true for a child to be in the room. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

A: To caution that a widely cited association may be produced by factors other than the one usually credited

B: To argue that musical training has no real effect on students' mathematical ability

C: To describe the material barriers that keep many students out of school orchestra programs

D: To recommend that districts remove the costs that restrict participation in school music

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: TECHNIQUE - NOT X BUT Y. Hunt for the sentence pattern 'the point is not X; it is Y.' It hands you the purpose and simultaneously names a distractor. Osei supplies it verbatim: not that training does nothing, but that the comparison cannot separate training from everything else that had to be true. Why A: an association possibly produced by other factors. Why not B: the X the passage explicitly disowns. Students still choose it because the middle of the passage reads as a takedown of orchestra research, and the disclaimer arrives late. Whenever you meet a 'not X' sentence, go back to the options and cross out X immediately, before you evaluate anything else. Why not C: the instrument, lessons, and transport list is his evidence for a confound. Why not D: no policy is proposed. A passage may describe a barrier without asking anyone to remove it.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 45

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Two accounts dominate scholarship on the collapse of the Classic Maya cities between roughly 800 and 950 CE. Hydrologist Cesar Poot assigns primary weight to a sequence of multidecadal droughts recorded in sediment cores from Lake Chichancanab, arguing that the reservoir systems supporting the largest centers held no reserve against failures on that scale. Historian Ingrid Sundqvist points instead to a marked increase in fortification, defaced monuments, and abandoned satellite settlements across the same window, and notes that droughts of comparable severity in the sixth century produced no collapse at all. Each has answered the other in print more than once. The sediment record has been read by different specialists as supporting both positions, and no excavation now planned would distinguish between them, since warfare and water stress leave overlapping signatures in the same deposits. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A: To argue that drought was the decisive factor in the collapse of the Classic Maya cities
- B: To lay out two competing scholarly accounts of a historical collapse without settling between them
- C: To explain why the archaeological evidence bearing on the Maya collapse is unlikely to prove decisive
- D: To trace how scholarly understanding of the Maya collapse has changed over several decades

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: TECHNIQUE - SPACE AUDIT. Count the words each side receives. Poot gets a full sentence with named evidence; Sundqvist gets a full sentence with named evidence and a counterexample. Roughly equal space plus 'each has answered the other' plus evidence read as supporting both means the passage is holding a debate open, not resolving it. Why B: two competing accounts, no settlement. Why not A: picks a side the writer refuses to pick. Why not C: the strongest trap, taken from the final sentence about overlapping signatures. That sentence explains why the debate persists; it does not convert the passage into an argument about evidentiary limits. A useful rule: a final sentence usually reinforces the purpose rather than replacing it. Why not D: 'has changed over several decades' implies a sequence in which one view supplanted another. Both views are live and current.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 46

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Debate over whether birdsong is innate or learned has often proceeded as though an answer on one side would settle the matter. Neuroethologist Tomas Berg points to two findings that sit awkwardly with either position. A white-crowned sparrow raised in acoustic isolation produces a song that is rough and simplified but unmistakably that of its species, having never heard one. The same bird will never acquire the dialect of its home valley, and will never be treated as local by the birds holding territory there, unless it hears an adult tutor during a window of roughly fifty days in its first summer; after that the window closes and no amount of exposure reopens it. What is inherited, Berg suggests, is neither the song nor a blank capacity to learn any song, but a narrow readiness to acquire one particular kind of song at one particular time. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A: To argue that birdsong is more learned than it is genetically inherited
- B: To describe the developmental window during which young sparrows acquire a local dialect
- C: To show that an either/or framing fails to capture how a behavior actually develops
- D: To propose that what birds inherit is a timing mechanism rather than a song

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: TECHNIQUE - BINARY IN LINE ONE. When a passage opens by naming an either/or, expect one of two outcomes: it picks a side, or it dissolves the frame. Read the last sentence to see which. Berg's close is 'neither the song nor a blank capacity,' a double negation, so the frame is being dissolved. Why C: an either/or framing that fails to capture the development. Why not A: picks a horn of the dilemma the passage rejects. Why not B: the fifty-day window is one of two findings offered against the binary, and isolated findings are supporting parts. Why not D: the most demanding trap in this set, because it paraphrases the final sentence. Check it word by word. Berg says a narrow readiness to acquire one particular kind of song at one particular time. D reduces that to a timing mechanism and drops the song-specificity, which is half his claim. Near-paraphrases of a real sentence are the hardest wrong answers to catch.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 47

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: The following text is from Marek Solheim's 2021 novel *The Ferry at Ostend*. Ines had written the letter in November, rewritten it in January, and rewritten it again in the week after her birthday, and the third version was better than the first two in every respect she could name, which was how she knew she was not going to send it. A letter that good has been worked on. Work is what you do to a thing instead of doing something with it. She read it through once more, folded it along the creases it already had, and put it in the drawer with the other two and with the four from the previous spring. The drawer was not a decision. She was very clear with herself on that point, and she closed it gently, the way one closes a drawer that is not a decision. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

A: To describe the care with which Ines composes correspondence she considers important

B: To convey Ines's regret over a relationship she has permitted to lapse

C: To illustrate Ines's settled resolve to end contact with the letter's intended recipient

D: To depict a character postponing a choice while insisting to herself that none is being made

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: TECHNIQUE - IRONIC ECHO. When a narrator states something flatly and the prose then repeats it in an odd construction, the text is disagreeing with the character. 'The drawer was not a decision' is followed by 'she closed it gently, the way one closes a drawer that is not a decision.' No neutral narrator writes that sentence. The echo signals that the denial is false. Why D: postponing a choice while insisting none is being made. Why not C: the mirror-image error, treating the drawer as a resolution reached. Both C and D read the denial; C believes it in one direction, D catches the irony. Why not A: the passage defines her rewriting for you, in its own words: work is what you do to a thing instead of doing something with it. That is avoidance, not care. Why not B: 'four from the previous spring' hints at history, but no relationship, no lapse, and no regret is ever specified.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 48

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Adding a lane to a congested highway frequently fails to reduce travel times, and in some corridors travel times are worse five years after the expansion than before it. Transport economist Junia Vasconcelos traces the result to a mistake in how capacity is ordinarily modeled: as fixed supply meeting fixed demand. Demand on an urban corridor is not fixed. Drivers who had shifted to earlier departures, to parallel routes, or to transit come back once the corridor appears faster; trips not worth making at forty minutes are worth making at twenty-five; and development follows the new capacity within a few years. Each adjustment pushes delay back toward the level commuters were already willing to tolerate. Vasconcelos is careful to say the lane is not wasted. It moves substantially more people than the corridor moved before, which is a real gain, though not the gain that was advertised. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A: To account for why an intuitive solution to a problem produces an unexpected result
- B: To argue that highway expansion projects are a poor use of public money
- C: To describe the travel adjustments commuters make when a corridor becomes faster
- D: To identify an error in the way transport planners model demand for road capacity

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: TECHNIQUE - OPEN AND CLOSE MATCH. On explanatory passages, read the first and last sentences together and see what they share. Here both are about the outcome: travel times fail to improve, and the lane moves more people but not faster. The middle supplies mechanism. When the frame is the phenomenon, the purpose is accounting for the phenomenon. Why A: accounts for why an intuitive fix yields an unexpected result. Why not D: the hardest trap here, since the passage does name a modeling mistake in its second sentence. But that mistake is the instrument of the account, not the target of it. Ask whether the passage would still make sense if the modeling language were removed. It would; the outcome would still need explaining. Why not B: blocked by 'the lane is not wasted,' and by 'a real gain.' Why not C: the returning drivers and induced trips are steps inside the mechanism.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 49

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: The first stable organocatalyst is credited in most textbooks to the laboratory of Henrik Sorensen, whose 1971 paper is the universal citation. Chemist Adaora Mbeki, working through a corporate archive opened to researchers in 2019, has found bound notebooks, a characterization report, and an internal technical memorandum describing the preparation of the same compound eighteen months earlier by Junko Arai, a staff chemist whose employment contract assigned publication rights to her employer and whose employer saw no commercial reason to publish. The memorandum records melting point, yield, and a proposed mechanism differing from Sorensen's in one respect later shown to be correct. Mbeki does not suggest that Sorensen knew of the earlier work, and notes that independent discovery within two years was common in the field at the time. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

A: To argue that Henrik Sorensen took credit for work he knew was not his own

B: To present evidence that a discovery credited to one laboratory had been made earlier by an overlooked chemist

C: To criticize the contractual arrangements that prevented an industrial chemist from publishing her work

D: To describe the preparation and chemical properties of the first stable organocatalyst

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: TECHNIQUE - DISCLAIMER SENTENCE. Priority disputes almost always carry a sentence saying what is not being alleged. Find it before choosing. Mbeki's is 'does not suggest that Sorensen knew of the earlier work,' plus a note that independent discovery was common. That converts the passage from an accusation into a record correction. Why B: a discovery credited to one laboratory was made earlier by an overlooked chemist. Why not A: the disclaimer exists to stop exactly this. It tempts because the setup, a famous man credited and an unknown woman erased, matches a story students already know. Beware of options that complete a familiar narrative the passage has declined to complete. Why not C: the contract explains why Arai went unpublished. It supplies cause, not target. Why not D: melting point, yield, and mechanism appear as proof of priority, not as a chemistry lesson.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 50

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Main Purpose

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Projections of carbon release from thawing permafrost rest almost entirely on measurements taken in the upper three meters of soil, the depth at which instruments can be installed and serviced without specialized drilling. Soil scientist Kirra Nightingale sets out what that leaves out. Something close to half the carbon held in Arctic permafrost lies below three meters, much of it in deep yedoma deposits that are ice-rich, organic-dense, and known to collapse rather than thaw gradually once destabilized. Thaw behavior at those depths has been measured at fewer than a dozen sites worldwide. Current models handle the deeper layers by extending the shallow parameters downward, which amounts to assuming the two behave alike. Nightingale's point is not that the assumption is wrong. It is that nothing in the present record establishes whether it is right. Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A: To argue that current projections substantially understate future carbon release from permafrost
- B: To explain why instruments cannot easily be installed in permafrost below three meters
- C: To identify a gap in existing measurements and note that an assumption built into current models is untested
- D: To describe the distinctive physical properties of deep yedoma permafrost deposits

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: TECHNIQUE - FINAL REFUSAL. Some passages spend their whole length building toward a conclusion and then explicitly decline to draw it. When the last sentence says something is unknown, the purpose stops at the gap. Nightingale's close is a double move: not that the assumption is wrong, but that nothing establishes whether it is right. Why C: identifies a measurement gap and an untested modelling assumption. Why not A: the trap the entire passage is engineered to set. Every fact points one way. Half the carbon is deep, yedoma collapses rather than thaws gradually, fewer than a dozen sites are measured. A student adds them up and concludes projections are too low, which is the inference she refuses. Discipline yourself to stop where the writer stops. Why not D: yedoma properties are evidence for the gap. Why not B: the three-meter instrument limit is the cause of the gap, and a cause is not a purpose.

END QUESTION